

# Prosperity Building

A 12-Step Guide  
to constructing quality of life  
and community prosperity.

Lee County, NC 2025

Prosperity Builder Scorecard™  
Rose & Associates Southeast, Inc.  
Kathleen Rose, CCIM, CRE



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# Introduction

**Where it began.** Our work at Rose Associates began in 1992 in New England after the Savings and Loan crisis caused many real estate development companies to pause due to a lack of capital for new projects. After years working in land acquisition and development, it became apparent that many developers did not do adequate due diligence on the markets, and built what banks were willing to fund. Our work began with project forensics, market analysis and repositioning of projects – for developers, lenders, and loan servicers. As a result of fond memories at Lake Lure, NC with family and teaching CCIM 102 Market Analysis courses in the Carolinas – decided to make the move to the Charlotte Region.

In 1999 the search began for a home which landed our family and firm in Davidson, North Carolina. Davidson was home to Davidson College and had the quaint fabric of a small downtown reminiscent of many of the small towns in rural New England. After settling into a newly built home in a largely undeveloped area of town close to the interstate, considered the “wrong side of the tracks” we began to explore our new town.

Downtown had many buildings that were empty, and some were neglected. What it did have was collaborative leadership and many passionate folks, both old timers and newcomers, who wanted to make their downtown vibrant. And so, the story of the rebirth of downtown Davidson began. Today, after 20 years of plans, efforts, and investment, it has become an overnight success. It has won multiple awards and accolades. I was proud to be a small part of it. Our work there became our case study for building prosperity.

-Kathleen Rose, CCIM, CRE®

***“Davidson Is the North Carolina Town That's Straight Out of a Hallmark Movie” ~ Southern Living Magazine***

***<https://www.southernliving.com/travel/north-carolina/davidson-nc>***





*Historic Downtown Davidson*

## Defining Prosperity

### *How do you define success?*

As with many small towns, community leaders often have different perspectives on what success means. A successful downtown? Plentiful jobs? Low taxes? A new road? Affordable housing?

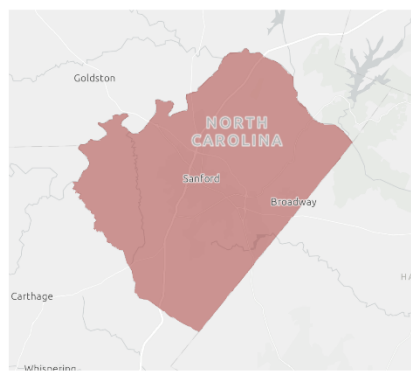
It all begins with a Vision. Community leaders, including elected officials, municipal staff and community stakeholders, must come together to create a unified vision of how it defines success, and a mission statement on how to get there, along with goals and strategies. Define what prosperity means for you – create a Vision & Mission.

***“If everyone is moving forward together, then success takes care of itself.” - Henry Ford***

# Prosperity Builder Scorecard™

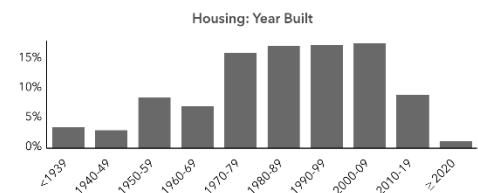
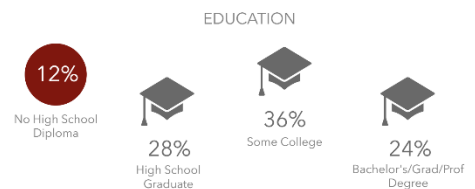
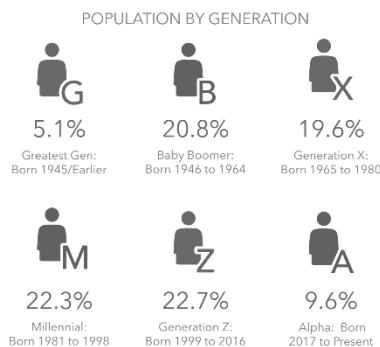
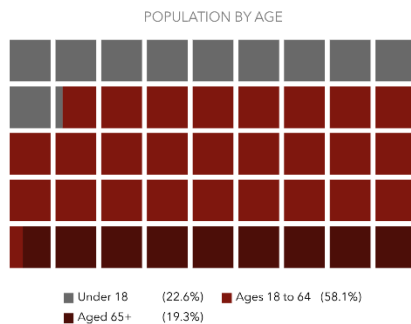
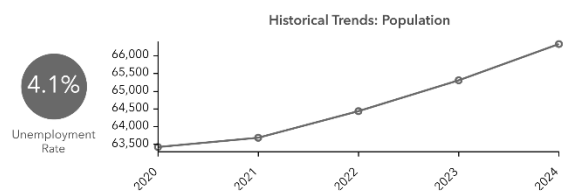
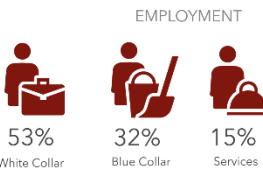
The Scorecard is our foundational Reality Check tool. It is designed to provide a qualitative and quantitative measure of how well land use, real estate, and economic development decisions accomplish the community's vision and goals, and its impact on quality of life. The Scorecard incorporates 12 categories under which approximately 90 data points assist in providing a comprehensive view, unique to your community. The data measures local performance benchmarked against state/national averages to help establish funding and policy priorities.

The first step is a self-assessment questionnaire conducted during an initial onsite visit. This, together with other data is collected to develop your Scorecard.



## Population Trends and Key Indicators

|            |            |                    |            |                         |                   |              |                       |                 |
|------------|------------|--------------------|------------|-------------------------|-------------------|--------------|-----------------------|-----------------|
| 66,330     | 26,120     | 2.50               | 40.4       | \$57,774                | \$275,875         | 77           | 82                    | 73              |
| Population | Households | Avg Size Household | Median Age | Median Household Income | Median Home Value | Wealth Index | Housing Affordability | Diversity Index |

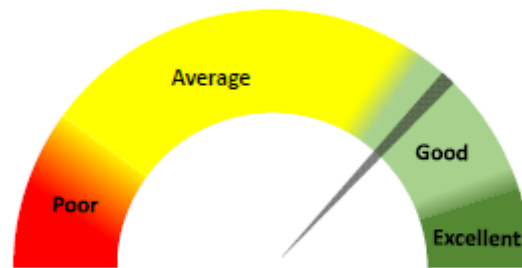


Source: This infographic contains data provided by Esri (2024, 2029), ACS (2018-2022), © 2025 Esri

Your Scorecard report is provided on the following pages:

# Prosperity Builder Scorecard™

## Quality of Life



74

Lee County, North Carolina  
Overall Score



Score: 80

### Accessibility & Transportation

*How well can residents, visitors and workers move in and around your community.*



Score: 74

### Arts & Culture

*Does your community foster and support local and visiting artists.*



Score: 61

### Crime & Public Safety

*Do residents, visitors and workers feel safe in your community.*



Score: 63

### Education

*Does your community provide resources for educational attainment.*



Score: 53

### Employment & Labor

*Is there a balanced workforce that provides business opportunity and expansion*



Score: 72

### Goods & Services

*Are there adequate offerings for food, beverages and other goods.*



Score: 59

### Healthcare & Wellness

*What is the status of public health and access to medical care.*



Score: 100

### Historic Preservation

*Does your community preserve and honor its historic assets.*



Score: 95

### Population & Housing

*Is there adequate and affordable housing for all generations.*



Score: 81

### Infrastructure

*Does your current infrastructure meet the needs of your community and expansion for the future.*



Score: 77

### Open Space & Recreation

*Are there ample opportunities for both passive and active recreation in your community.*



Score: 78

### Planning & Land Use

*Does your land use provide for preservation and a balanced tax base.*



# Accessibility & Transportation

*How well can residents, visitors and workers move in and around your community?*

Often, we defer to roads to provide a network of transportation. Many communities are car-dependent; however, it is important to explore other alternative modes of transportation. In addition to rail and air, other shared forms of transportation may include bus service or micro-transit, offering rideshare or other services.

***“The reality about transportation is that it's future-oriented. If we're planning for what we have, we're behind the curve.”***

***~ Anthony Foxx***

Universal design considers transportation planning for all abilities – this may include biking, walking, strolling and rolling, including accessibility for wheelchairs. This integrates both land use and transportation planning for one seamless plan of mobility.

Information on transportation, including statistics can be found at the U.S. Department of Transportation, and its [Bureau of Transportation Statistics](#).





# Your Accessibility & Transportation Score

Score:



## Accessibility & Transportation

*How well can residents, visitors and workers move in and around your community.*

| Accessibility & Transportation                         | Nation             | Local Data |
|--------------------------------------------------------|--------------------|------------|
| <b>Major Routes (#)</b>                                |                    |            |
| Interstate                                             | I-40               | 1          |
| US Highway                                             | US-1, 421, 501     | 3          |
| State Highway                                          | -                  | 4          |
| <b>Households w/o a Vehicle</b>                        | 8.3% (ACS 2017-202 | 4.0%       |
| <b>Average commute time (min.)</b>                     | 26.8 (2023)        | 25.7       |
| <b>Public transportation options (#)</b>               |                    |            |
| Airports                                               | -                  | 1          |
| Trains (Amtrak)                                        | -                  | 1          |
| Rapid Bus Transit                                      | -                  | -          |
| City Bus                                               | -                  | 1          |
| Trolley/Other                                          | -                  | -          |
| Local Rideshare/Micro Transit                          | -                  | 0.5        |
| <b>State transportation funds (# of STIP projects)</b> | -                  | 12         |
| <b>Bike and Ped Plan</b>                               | 2023               | Yes        |

## Summary

Lee County is very car dependent. This is largely due to its size and location. Three US Highways: 1, 421, and 501 converge at the center of the county in Sanford providing its primary trade routes. COLTS is a local bus system, and micro transit is being considered. Most households own a vehicle to travel to work, for shopping and other trips. A Long-Range Transportation Plan is underway with the NC Department of Transportation and local municipal partners. Details can be found [here](#). A mobility hub study is underway with the rails systems serving the reion. Lee County, NC does not currently have a publicly available, specific "Bicycle & Pedestrian Plan" document. However, the 2018 Lee County Comprehensive Plan does address bicycle and pedestrian facilities as part of its overall transportation planning, aiming to improve connectivity and safety for all users.

*All data is based upon the most recent figures available as of 2023 unless otherwise noted.*





# Arts & Culture

*Does your community foster and support local and visiting artists?*

Museums, performing and visual arts are among the key elements of arts and culture. Public art such as murals, sculptures and other art provides visual interest, highlights local culture and history. It can also create a destination for visitors, supporting the tourism industry. The U.S. Bureau of Economic Analysis (BEA) showed that arts and cultural economic activity, adjusted for inflation, increased 4.8 percent in 2022 after increasing 10.8 percent in 2021. North Carolina's nonprofit arts and culture industry generated \$2.23 billion in economic activity in 2022, according to a report by the North Carolina Arts Council.

*"Art is the signature of civilizations."*

- Beverly Sills



Clayton, NC - Sculpture Trail



Sanford, NC - Mural Art Trail





# Your Arts & Culture Score

Score:



## Arts & Culture

*Does your community foster and support local and visiting artists.*

| Arts & Culture                                    | Nation | Local Data |
|---------------------------------------------------|--------|------------|
| Public Art installations (#)                      | -      |            |
| Public Art                                        |        | Y          |
| Murals                                            |        | 30         |
| Public Art Map                                    |        | Y          |
| Cultural facilities (Theatre, museum, art, music) | -      |            |
| Arts/Community Center                             |        | -          |
| Museum                                            |        | 1          |
| Theatre                                           |        | 2          |
| Event Venues                                      |        | 4          |
| Event Programs (Festivals, etc)                   | -      | 7          |
| % of employment in Arts, Entertainment Sector     | 1.89%  | 0.9%       |

## Summary

Lee County has a robust arts scene supported by the Lee County Arts Council and Sanford Appearance Commission. Public art and a mural trail provide cultural interest and highlights the county's rich history. Temple Theatre is an historic performance center located in the heart of downtown Sanford. [Visit Sanford](#) is the area's tourism authority and provides information and resource for arts, culture and events. And along with music, Sanford was named Bee City USA. A new library and farmer's market further expand entrepreneurial opportunities. Continued marketing of its history, assets, and events will continue to build the arts and entertainment sector and attract talent through promotion of quality of life.

*All data is based upon the most recent figures available as of 2023 unless otherwise noted.*



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# Crime & Public Safety

*Do residents, visitors and workers feel safe in your community?*

Public safety is the protection of people and property from harm and danger. It includes preventing crime, responding to emergencies, and ensuring that roads and buildings are safe. These are the primary responsibilities of any municipality. Police, Fire, Emergency Medical Services (EMS) and Public Works Departments assist in ensuring public safety. It is the second level of Maslow's safety needs.

When public safety is at risk, it negatively impacts local economies. When a community is perceived to be safe – families and businesses move in, and tourism grows. Protecting people and property is the primary function of local law enforcement. Crime is tracked by law enforcement agencies which report to the [FBI](#). Crime statistics are broken down by personal crime – murder, rape, robbery & assault; and property crime – burglary, larceny & car theft.

Natural disaster recovery is a long, often challenging process for affected communities. While the immediate aftermath is marked by urgent relief efforts, true recovery extends far beyond the first few days or weeks. It involves rebuilding infrastructure, homes, and livelihoods, but also addressing the emotional and psychological toll on individuals. Resilient communities emerge when there is a collective effort from government agencies such as [FEMA](#), nonprofits, and local residents. Effective recovery also means creating systems that are better prepared for future disasters, fostering stronger connections, and prioritizing sustainable rebuilding efforts.

Elected leadership and municipal staff determine policies and ordinances that set the tone for law enforcement and public safety.



# Your Crime & Public Safety Score

Score:



## Crime & Public Safety

*Do residents, visitors and workers feel safe in your community.*

| Crime & Public Safety                              | Nation | Local Data |
|----------------------------------------------------|--------|------------|
| Personal Crime Index                               | 100    | 85         |
| Property Crime Index < 100                         | 100    | 92         |
| Bonus: Officer to Resident Ratio (per 1,000 reside | 2.8    | 2.9        |

## Summary

Lee County and the municipalities within it are generally perceived as safe communities and its crime rates score below the national average. The ratio of officers to residents slightly exceeds the nation. As with many communities, recruitment presents both challenges and opportunities. A new county jail is planned as well as a new fire station near large residential developments along US Highway 1.



*All data is based upon the most recent figures available as of 2023 unless otherwise noted.*



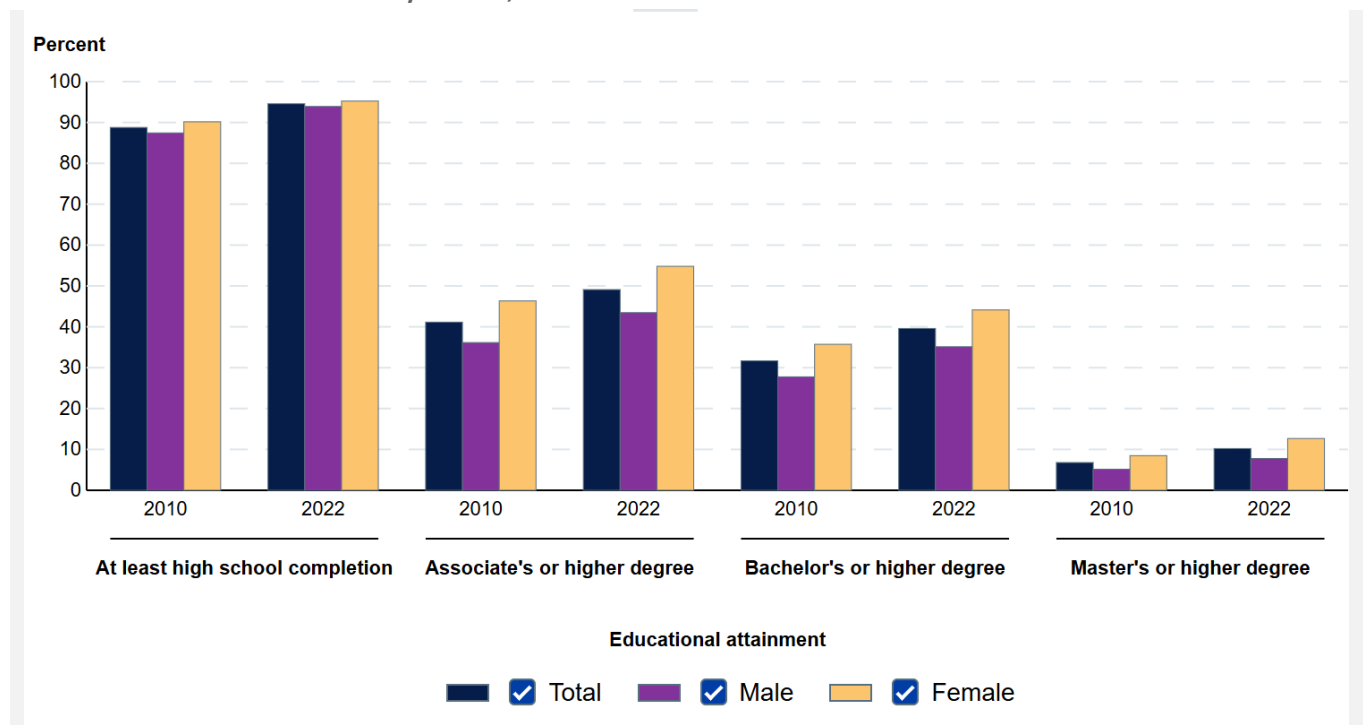
# Education



## *Does your community provide resources for educational attainment?*

The correlation between education, employment, and income is impacted by job readiness. Primary K-12 education is provided by public and private schools. Trade schools and community colleges can be the next step in the journey of job readiness, providing skills and training. Further education through colleges and universities leads to professional vocations. Educational attainment is the level of education completed by adults. This is tracked through [educational attainment data](#) and local goals for providing workforce for business and industry attraction.

U.S. Educational Attainment 25–29-year-olds, 2010 and 2022



# Your Education Score



Score:

63

## Education

*Does your community provide resources for educational attainment.*

| Education                                              | Nation | Local Data |
|--------------------------------------------------------|--------|------------|
| HS Graduation                                          | 23.3%  | 28.2%      |
| College                                                |        |            |
| Some college, no degree                                | 17.7%  | 21.2%      |
| Associates Degree                                      | 9.5%   | 14.6%      |
| Bachelor Degree                                        | 22.3%  | 16.6%      |
| Graduate/PhD                                           | 13.9%  | 6.9%       |
| K-12 Performance (Low Performing Schools)              | -      | 28.6%      |
| K-12 Chronic Absentism                                 | -      | 23.24%     |
| Secondary Education (Trade Schools, Community College, |        |            |
| Community College/Trade School                         | -      | 1          |
| College/Universities                                   | -      | 0          |

## Summary

Lee County performs above the national average for high school graduates, along with some college and/or technical degrees at the local community colleges. However, it begins to lose ground for bachelor and graduate degrees. Partnering with regional colleges and universities (e.g. Campbell University) offering 4-year degrees will improve the workforce outcomes to attract future industries. And a focus on the trades also has made Lee County a competitive labor market for manufacturing.

*All data is based upon the most recent figures available as of 2023 unless otherwise noted.*



# Employment & Labor

*Is there a balanced workforce that provides business opportunity and expansion?*

In addition to understanding local Educational Attainment in building a workforce, local leaders must strive to create a balanced workforce that includes services, white collar and blue-collar employment. The United States has transitioned from a manufacturing-based economy (blue collar) to a service-based economy that includes both service workers and white-collar professionals.

***“In 2023, 6% of the total U.S. employees were self-employed”***  
***~ US Bureau of Labor Statistics***

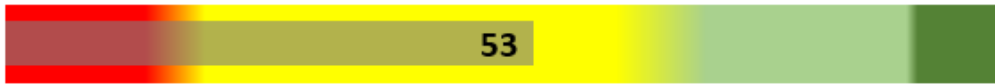
From tech workers to healthcare providers, understanding local employment sectors and how they impact the economy is necessary to plan future growth. This includes understanding the local economic base – or which sectors of the economy are performing better than the U.S. averages to determine their impact on local job growth. This can further determine future needs for various product types for land use planning. Details regarding industry employment sectors can be found at the [US Bureau of Labor Statistics](#).





# Your Employment & Labor Score

Score:



## Employment & Labor

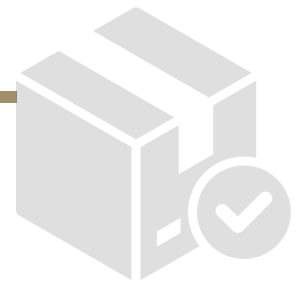
*Is there a balanced workforce that provides business opportunity and expansion.*

| Employment & Labor               | Nation    | Local Data |
|----------------------------------|-----------|------------|
| % White Collar Employed          | 65%       | 50.1%      |
| % Blue Collar Employed           | 22%       | 32.2%      |
| % Services Employed              | 14%       | 17.7%      |
| Unemployment Rate*               | 4.3%      | 3.5%       |
| Labor Participation              | 63.0%     | 60.1%      |
| Average HH Income                | \$107,008 | \$83,474   |
| Median HH Income                 | \$72,603  | \$57,774   |
| Per Capita Income                | \$41,310  | \$32,898   |
| Certified Pad Ready Sites        | -         | 2000 Acres |
| Available buildings > 5000 SF    | -         | 5          |
| Large Employers 500+             | -         | 4          |
| Large Employers 1000+            | -         | 4          |
| <b>BONUS: HQ/Fortune 500/100</b> | -         | 3          |

## Summary

As noted in the Education category, Lee County could expand plans and policies to attract talent in a variety of industries and balance its workforce. There is a direct correlation between levels of educational attainment and income. The launch of Central Carolina Enterprise Park is one indicator that opportunity lies in expanded industrial development. Neighboring manufacturers such as Caterpillar, Pfizer, and Astellas offer expanded industry opportunities, such as life sciences.

*All data is based upon the most recent figures available as of 2023 unless otherwise noted.*



# Goods & Services

*Are there adequate offerings for food, beverages & other goods?*

Many communities define success by attracting a Starbucks, Chick-Fil-A or other national chain restaurants or grocery stores. However, many of these operators require a minimum threshold of population or drive-by traffic to consider a location. Do you have a major interstate or state highway location? Are you a destination? Is there a major employer that drives daytime population?

Walmart began as a small local operator in rural Arkansas to replace the General Store. Today, that need is being filled by Dollar Stores or Dollar General. Food and beverage operators are often the only viable option in many small and rural communities.

***The International Council of Shopping Centers provides data  
on the state of the Marketplaces Industry  
Find information [here](#).***

Both urban and rural communities can benefit from collaborating with local farmers to provide fresh offerings through farmers' markets, farm to table restaurants and local shared kitchens for producing locally made food products.



*Fred's Mercantile - Beech Mountain, NC*





# Your Goods & Services Score

Score:



## Goods & Services

*Are there adequate offerings for food, beverages and other goods.*

| Goods & Services                               | Nation | Local Data |
|------------------------------------------------|--------|------------|
| % Employed in Retail Trade                     | 12.2%  | 9.8%       |
| % Employed in Accommodations & Food Services   | 9.4%   | 10.3%      |
| % Employed in Arts, Entertainment & Recreation | 2.4%   | 0.9%       |
| Retail Vacancy                                 | 4.0%   | 2.1%       |

## Summary

Lee County has a retail sector characterized by a mix of local businesses and larger chain stores, particularly in the Sanford area. It has relied on its regional population to fuel retail trade. The retail market is strong; however, it could strengthen its food and beverage connection to its downtowns and rural communities through collaboration with Visit Sanford and visitors to the Temple Theatre and the Dennis A. Wicker Civic & Conference Center. A recent retail leakage study indicated additional demand for a department store and other convenience uses.

*All data is based upon the most recent figures available as of 2023 unless otherwise noted.*



# Healthcare & Wellness

*What is the status of public health and access to medical care?*

Healthcare is both a local and national conversation. Most counties conduct annual Public Health Assessments to determine the health of its citizens, and access to health care. This might also include social issues that impact health such as food and housing security, and other factors. This begins with a baseline health assessment in your community to determine services, facilities and resources connected to health. Partnering between healthcare providers and local parks and recreation services is one example of linking health related assets within a community.

The Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (CDC) and the Surgeon General address outbreaks of disease, particularly post pandemic, and other public health related issues. Its new ONE HEALTH approach applies across local, regional, national, and global levels to address health safety and preparedness.

## ONE HEALTH



One Health is a collaborative, multisectoral, and transdisciplinary approach with the goal of achieving optimal health outcomes that recognizes the interconnection between people, animals, plants, and their shared environment.

CONNECTING HUMAN, ANIMAL, AND ENVIRONMENTAL HEALTH



# Your Healthcare & Wellness Score

Score:



## Healthcare & Wellness

*What is the status of public health and access to medical care.*

| Healthcare & Wellness                       |             | Nation                    | Local Data |
|---------------------------------------------|-------------|---------------------------|------------|
| Hospitals                                   | 135 Beds    | 2.9 Beds/ 1000 population | 2.0        |
| Clinics, Medical Facilities                 |             | -                         | 5          |
| County Health Factors                       |             | -                         | 57         |
| Air Quality Index                           | NC = 7.8mcg | -                         | 8.3        |
| Households Below Poverty Level (ACS 5 Year) |             | 11.1% (2023)              | 15.0%      |
| Access to Healthy Food                      |             | -                         | Y          |
| % Employed in Healthcare Sector             |             | 14.9% (2023)              | 11.3%      |

## Summary

Central Carolina Hospital has a 135 bed facility providing healthcare along with other urgent and non-urgent care needs. Making the connection between health and wellness and recreation should be an important goal for Lee County. Partnerships between healthcare providers and recreational assets such as parks and greenways can improve the overall wellbeing of its residents. More information on County Health Factors and the rankings can be found [here](#).

*All data is based upon the most recent figures available as of 2023 unless otherwise noted.*



# Historic Preservation

*Does your community preserve and honor its historic assets?*

As communities grow, many historic structures including homes and downtown buildings suffer from neglect and decay. [Historic preservation](#) is increasingly becoming a specialized field, as renovators and investors seek assets that qualify for tax credits. It is especially important to define a community's unique character, and it tries to define its value proposition. Historic places can't be replaced once they are destroyed.



***“There may have been a time when preservation was about saving an old building, but those days are gone. Preservation is in the business of saving communities and the values they embody”***

**~ National Trust for Historic Preservation**



# Your Historic Preservation Score

Score:



## Historic Preservation

*Does your community preserve and honor its historic assets.*

| Historic Preservation                                        | Nation | Local Data |
|--------------------------------------------------------------|--------|------------|
| Historic Districts                                           | -      | 4          |
| Main St. Designation                                         | -      | Y          |
| Downtown or Main St. Manager                                 | -      | Y          |
| Registered Buildings                                         | -      | 16         |
| Municipal Service or Business Improvement District (MSD/BID) |        | Y          |
| Historic Tour Map                                            |        | Y          |

## Summary

Lee County excels in this category, largely due to the efforts of downtown Sanford. Alliances with organizations such as the [North Carolina Main Street & Rural Center](#) and [State Office of Historic Preservation](#) have provided significant resources in the preservation of historic structures. To highlight this strength, marketing efforts could further elevate tourism opportunities beyond

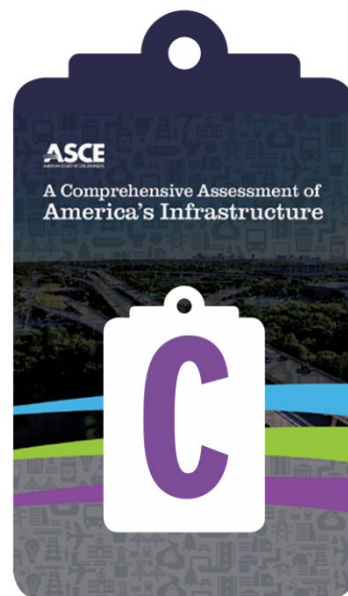
*All data is based upon the most recent figures available as of 2023 unless otherwise noted.*



# Infrastructure

*Does your current infrastructure meet the needs of your community and expansion for the future?*

Every four years, the [American Society of Civil Engineers' Report Card](#) for America's Infrastructure depicts the condition and performance of American infrastructure in the familiar form of a school report card—assigning letter grades based on the physical condition and needed investments for improvement. The ASCE grade for 2025 was a C.



The Report Card includes a broad list of categories including roads, bridges, dams, drinking water, wastewater and stormwater, among others. Most recently, there has been added emphasis on energy and broadband, as advancing technologies impact our infrastructure grids.





# Your Infrastructure Score

Score:



## Infrastructure

*Does your current infrastructure meet the needs of your community and future expansion.*

| Infrastructure                          | Nation | Local Data |
|-----------------------------------------|--------|------------|
| Public Sewer Capacity (Availability)    | -      | Y          |
| Public Water Capacity (Availability)    | -      | Y          |
| Public Electric Capacity (Availability) | -      | Y          |
| Broadband Availability                  | -      | 67.44      |
| Expansion Plans                         | -      | Y          |
| Roadways (STIP)                         | -      | Y          |
| Water Quality (Stormwater)              | -      | B          |
| Emergency Planning                      | -      | Y          |
| <b>BONUS: Green Energy Alternatives</b> | -      | Y          |

## Summary

Lee County has a keen sense of its infrastructure. TriRiver Water has capacity and plans to expand distribution, and there is currently a study to expand sewer capacity. Duke Energy and Central Electric are in the process of upgrading to 100 megawatts for expanded industrial development. And there are multiple options for fiber connectivity. However, it must use caution in expanding public utilities without adequate consideration for land use planning. Often development follows such expansion which can lead to sprawl and challenge other areas such as transportation and impact overall quality of life. Given proximity to the nuclear plant, public safety and emergency planning are also robust. The county is currently supportive of alternative energy resources such as solar.

*All data is based upon the most recent figures available as of 2023 unless otherwise noted.*



# Open Space & Recreation

*Are there ample opportunities for both passive and active recreation in your community?*

Increasingly, homebuyers are making decisions about communities based on the availability of recreation, including passive recreation such as parks and greenways, and active recreation, such as sportsplexes and health parks that provide exercise stations. It is also being a public health issue, as the U.S. rate of obesity climbs. According to the National Institutes of Health, in 2023 nearly 1 in 3 adults (30.7%) are overweight. And more than 2 in 5 adults (42.4%) have obesity (including severe obesity).

What are the recreational assets in your community?  
Do you have any local public parks or state parks in your region?

***“On average, park and recreation agencies across the country provide one park for every 2,386 residents” ~***

***ASCE***

**Public Parks | ASCE's 2025 Infrastructure Report Card**



*Lee County Athletic Park*



# Your Open Space & Recreation Score

Score:



**Open Space & Recreation**  
*Are there ample opportunities for both passive and active recreation in your community.*

| Open Space & Recreation       | Nation | Local Data |
|-------------------------------|--------|------------|
| Recreation Plan               | -      | Y          |
| Parks and Rec Director        | -      | Y          |
| Greenway                      | -      | Y          |
| Natural/Recreational Assets   | -      | Y          |
| Open Space/Parks              | -      | 18         |
| Conservation Ordinances       | -      | Y          |
| BONUS: National or State Park | -      | 1          |

## Summary

This is one of Lee County’s greatest opportunities. It should celebrate these 18 differentiating assets in attracting visitors, new residents and business, which highlights the quality of life in Lee County. Lee County Athletic Park’s \$40 million dollar investment opening in September, provides local and tournament games. The Sand Lee Park is a regional destination for mountain biking and recreation. The county is Lee County, NC, is actively engaged in developing and improving its recreational offerings. A recent master planning effort focused on four key parks (Horton Park, Kiwanis Children’s Park, Temple Park, and O.T. Sloan Park) to enhance recreation experiences and community connectivity. Given its history in agriculture, may wish to consider further preservation efforts in its farmlands.

*All data is based upon the most recent figures available as of 2023 unless otherwise noted.*

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# Population & Housing

*Is there adequate and affordable housing for all generations?*



When reflecting on prosperity, one might consider Maslow's Hierarchy of Needs – Maslow, an American psychologist proposed that human beings possess two types of needs – deficiency needs and growth needs. Among the threshold physiological needs, including air, water and food is **shelter**.

Housing is a basic need and is often the majority land use in every municipality. The formation of community begins with people – beginning with the settling of our country nearly 250 years ago. Housing policy in the U.S. evolved from major economic events in the 20<sup>th</sup> century.

***“There's no place like home”  
- Dorothy in the Wizard of Oz***

The Depression in the 1930's limited access to home ownership for low-income families. Since then, housing policy has shifted from tenancy to home ownership which has dominated our economy and land use. Despite the focus on single-family homes and home ownership, changing economies, demographics and cultural shifts have put renewed focus on the importance of diversity of housing choices for all generations. Today, communities large and small, urban and rural, are facing housing shortages and affordability challenges. This is driving the rental market as few can afford to purchase.

According to the [National Association of Realtors 2024 Profile of Home Buyers and Sellers](#), “Multigenerational buyers climbed to an all-time high of 17% over the past year (up from 14% the previous year). Home buyers cited cost savings, elder care and accommodating young adults moving back home as reasons for purchasing a multigenerational home.” Whether renting or buying, most buyers want homes located adjacent to goods and services with access to recreation and parks/open space.



# Your Population & Housing Score

Score:



## Population & Housing

*Is there adequate and affordable housing for all generations.*

| Population & Housing                        | Nation            | Local Data |
|---------------------------------------------|-------------------|------------|
| Housing Units Renter Occupied               | 35.1%             | 32.3%      |
| Median Home Value                           | \$308,943 (2023)  | \$275,875  |
| Median Rent Price                           | \$1,348           | \$962      |
| Housing Structure Built (% newer than 1979) | 47.9% (2017-2021) | 62.0%      |
| Cost Burdened Households                    | 22.1% (2017-2021) | 17.3%      |
| <b>BONUS: Diversity Index</b>               | -                 | 73         |

## Summary

Lee County has benefited from the proximity and rapid growth of Raleigh. Much of the housing inventory in the county includes single family homes that were built over a period of decades, and Lee County has a competitively affordable and newer housing stock. With close to 10,000 entitled new home developments in the pipeline, only 0.06% are multifamily units. A land trust is providing 75 units of affordable housing, and there is a 36-bed homeless shelter under construction. With rising costs and affordability challenges nationally, communities in the county should seek to expand housing options beyond the single-family home to meet a changing demographic. Every generation has different housing needs which require a variety of housing types, such as townhomes, duplexes, apartments, elderly housing – both for rent and for sale – to meet current and future demand.

*All data is based upon the most recent figures available as of 2023 unless otherwise noted.*



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# Planning & Land Use

*Does your land use policy provide for preservation and a balanced tax base?*

Many communities are faced with development pressures, as new subdivisions build new homes and apartments, while manufacturers demand more land for large warehouse/distribution projects. This is most evident in the fast-growing areas of the southern United States. Annual reports on migration can be found on the Internal Revenue Service (IRS) website and reports published by national moving companies, such as U-Haul and United Van Lines. The trend of southern states netting larger numbers of one-way U-Haul® customers continued during 2024, with South Carolina topping the [U-Haul Growth Index](#) for the first time. Texas, North Carolina, Florida and Tennessee round out the five leading growth states.

***“Property values have skyrocketed in recent years, rising almost 27 percent faster than inflation since 2020, which yields dramatically higher property taxes in jurisdictions that fail to adjust millages (rates) downward.”***

***~ Tax Foundation***

With the growing emphasis on public health, infrastructure, and environmental issues – there must be a balance between the built environment and preservation of farmlands and public lands for recreation and/or conservation. This is often a challenge for local governments that must balance the tax base and the interests between residents demanding services and industries that require land and infrastructure to support business. Many communities face expanding tax-exempt uses, such as schools, churches and public parks, as they attempt to balance budgets to maintain services, while keeping property taxes within competitive limits. This is further complicated by rising costs of construction and home prices as revaluations challenge property owners’ costs.





## Your Planning & Land Use Score

Score:



### Planning & Land Use

*Does your land use provide for preservation and a balanced tax base.*

| Planning & Land Use                                  | Nation | Local Data |
|------------------------------------------------------|--------|------------|
| Voluntary Agricultural Districts (VAD) or (EVA)      | -      | Y          |
| % Agricultural Employment Sector                     | 0.5%   | 1.3%       |
| % Residential Property Tax Value                     | -      | 65.8%      |
| % Commercial Property Tax Value                      | -      | 34.2%      |
| Vacant Land (acres)                                  | -      | Y          |
| Tax Exempt Acreage (institutions, churches, schools) | -      |            |
| Comprehensive Land Use Plan (Year)                   |        | 2018 Y     |

## Summary

The last comprehensive plan update was in 2018, and a plan update will assist in determining the best course of action for future development. Lee County is well balanced between residential and commercial development, however, the planned residential development could alter this ratio. The burden of cost for providing services falls primarily on its resident citizens, therefore needs to continue to expand its commercial tax base. This would further provide both housing and job opportunities for residents to lessen the burden of a long commute to work, and expand shopping, dining and recreation/entertainment experiences.

*All data is based upon the most recent figures available as of 2023 unless otherwise noted.*

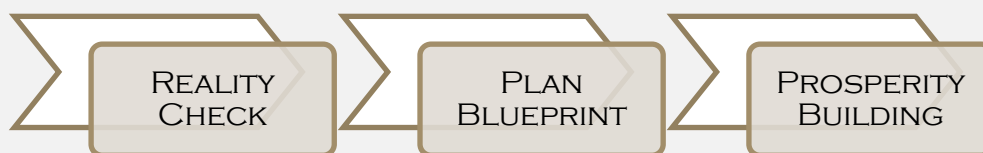


## Next Steps & Resources

### Where do we go from here?

The Scorecard provides a foundational first step in understanding your current reality. There are several resources available to assist communities in building prosperity. In addition to the Scorecard, these steps include the following:

- Understand your community characteristics and dynamics. This includes updated demographic and economic data from state and federal resources such as the U.S. Census and the Bureau of Labor Statistics.
- Set forth a Vision and Mission for your community. This requires input from local residents, business owners and other stakeholders.
- Identify your community assets. What makes your community special?



### *The Prosperity Builder Program™*

If further interested, join our Prosperity Builder Program. Our process begins by evaluating the community's health and well-being. We use a combination of data sources and tools that take a complex myriad of information, interpret it, and frame it into a scorecard that assists in prioritizing decisions based on market reality, vision and goals. This encourages dialogue between the local government staff, elected officials, citizens, business leaders and stakeholders. The next steps include building a plan and monitoring its success through a set of metrics meant to measure prosperity building progress. Reach out to us at [info@roseassociates.com](mailto:info@roseassociates.com) to schedule a consultation on building your best path forward.

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## **PHASE 1: REALITY CHECK — INITIAL ASSESSMENT**

This phase is about discovering who you are. Key indicators and trends assist in providing updated demographic and economic data for your community. With these data points, self-assessment is made, and additional data is collected to complete the Prosperity Builder Scorecard™, which quantifies and assesses your quality of life. Next, community leaders, armed with information gathered, come together to assess existing conditions and provide a foundation to work with. This data can be updated as needed and shared to prevent duplication of efforts in data collection across multiple plans and studies.

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## **PHASE 2: PLAN BLUEPRINT — CONSTRUCTING THE PLAN**

This phase is about deciding where you want to go. Identifying what areas need building, which need preservation and which need revitalization. A real estate market analysis and/or housing assessment will provide additional insights. From there, the Blueprint is constructed using strategies, goals and action steps for land use and/or economic development plans, including assignments for local staff, elected officials, business leaders, and community organizations. This provides the framework for a subsequent action or work plan.

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## **PHASE 3: PROSPERITY BUILDING — TRACKING PROGRESS & SUCCESSES**

This phase is about building your future. Once the Blueprint is built, the real work begins to implement. A periodic review of the workplan updates data, tracks progress and monitors annual performance. It includes finding builders, developers, and community champions to facilitate change, promoting your community and celebrating successes. And continued monitoring and maintenance is achieved through Blueprint Report updates.



**The Prosperity Builder Scorecard™ is a registered trademark.**

**The conclusions set forth are based upon information provided by public records, municipal officials, clients, market and demographic data obtained by Rose & Associates Southeast, Inc.**

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